

After doing so, if 'AutoFiltering' is turned on, the list appears with a blue outline—the outline gets thicker when the list is activated. As an option, you can choose to display summary formulas at the bottom in the 'total row'. You must choose these summary formulas from a dropdown list (custom formulas are not allowed). The formula that's created uses the SUBTOTAL function.

Novice users might like this new list feature, because it can prevent some errors. For example, if you insert a new row within your list, it doesn't actually insert a new row. Rather, it moves the subsequent cells in the list down so it doesn't mess up other non-list data to the left or right.

Other uses might be confused. After all, people have been using lists in Excel for about 15 years. When you refer to a list, do you mean a 'designated' list or a normal list?

A new toolbar, List and XML, appears when a list is active. This toolbar has commands to work with lists. For example, you can insert or delete rows, access the Sort dialog box, and access the data entry form.

Perhaps the most useful aspect of designating a list concerns charting. If you create a chart from data in a designated list, the chart series expands automatically when the list is augmented with new data. In the past, this type of 'auto-expanding' chart required using some non-intuitive names and editing the chart SERIES formula.

Related to the new list feature is an enhancement in the SUBTOTAL function. This has always been one of Excel's most confusing functions, and now it's even more confusing. Excel 2003 enables you to use this function to work with visible data only. You do this by adding 100 to the first argument. In the past, SUBTOTAL ignored hidden data only if the data was hidden by AutoFiltering or an outline. Now, the function works as expected even if the data is hidden manually.